

The wetland jewel of southern Africa

River deltas are so called due to their triangular shape, which resembles the Greek letter Δ, or delta. Most form where rivers deposit vast amounts of silt and sand close to the point at which they meet the sea, but the Okavango River in Botswana never finds the coast. Instead, it drains into a depression in the Kalahari Desert, fanning out to create the greatest oasis in Africa—a vast complex of permanent and seasonal swamps, reed beds, forests, and grasslands. The precise pattern of its waterways changes constantly from year to year as channels become blocked by sand, silt, and vegetation, and the slow-moving water backs up and is forced to find an alternative route.

Breathing space

Much of the water in the Okavango Delta's permanent swamps is oxygen-poor, so the fish and aquatic invertebrates that live there are adapted to extract oxygen from the air. The waters support an estimated 35 million fish of 80 species, while the greatest abundance and diversity of terrestrial life is found in marginal areas, where swamps populated by hippopotamuses and crocodiles are fringed with forest. This, in turn, gives way to open savannas, where huge herds of grazing animals attract top predators such as cheetahs, lions, hyenas, leopards, and wild dogs.

One of the **world's largest inland river deltas**, it swells to **three times its size** during winter

